

CAR-05 · CAREER ROADMAP

Into project controls leadership

The move from being right to being believed, and from owning a number to owning the system that produces it

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

Below leadership, a controls professional is measured on the accuracy of what they produce. At leadership they are measured on whether the organisation acts on it. This document sets out what changes: the four accountabilities of a controls leader, what a controls strategy actually decides, how a function is run rather than performed, how the relationship with the project director is constructed in advance, and the specific instrument — the movement bridge — that converts accuracy into credibility.

— About this document

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Contents

1. What changes	4
2. The four accountabilities	4
3. Setting a controls strategy	5
4. Running a function rather than performing one	5
5. The relationship with the project director	6
6. Being believed: the movement bridge and the habits around it	6
7. How this goes wrong	7
8. Worked example — the movement bridge	7
9. Checklist — before you take the role, and in the first cycle after	8
Related	9
Sources and standards	9
Status and version	9

Into project controls leadership

In one paragraph. The move into project controls leadership is not a larger version of the job below it. Below leadership you are measured on the accuracy of what you produce; at leadership you are measured on whether the organisation acts on it in time, and on whether the function can produce a defensible position without you. This document sets out the four accountabilities that come with the role, what a controls strategy actually decides, how to run a function rather than perform one, how to construct the relationship with the project director before you need it, and the single instrument — a movement bridge — that most reliably converts being right into being believed.

Who this is for. Cost managers, planning managers, project controls managers and heads of function, and the senior cost engineers and lead planners preparing for that step; also project directors who want to know what to expect from the role.

— 1. What changes

At rung three of either technical ladder — [CAR-03](#) for cost, [CAR-04](#) for planning — the job is to hold a defensible position. At leadership, three things change at once.

Your output is a decision, not a report. A correct forecast that arrives after the procurement commitment has been made has failed, however accurate it was. Timeliness is now part of correctness, and the calendar is a design decision you own.

You are accountable for numbers you did not check. The position now aggregates work by people you hired, using a process you designed. You cannot verify it all, so you must design controls that make undetected error unlikely and detected error early.

Being right becomes the entry ticket. It is assumed. What is now scarce is the ability to make an organisation act on an unwelcome number, which is a function of credibility, timing and the form in which the number arrives — not of its accuracy.

The failure of many strong technical practitioners at this step is to double down on the thing that got them here. They produce better analysis for a room that has already stopped listening, and conclude that the organisation is unserious. Occasionally that is true. More often the analysis was correct, late, unbridged and delivered to someone who had not been prepared for it.

— 2. The four accountabilities

That the position is true. Complete, reconciled, on a stated data date, with judgements labelled as judgements. This is inherited from the technical ladder and is non-negotiable.

That it arrives in time to change something. The reporting calendar is designed backwards from the decisions it must inform — the procurement commitment, the board review, the client submission — not forwards from when the data happens to be available. If the cycle cannot serve the decision, the cycle is wrong.

That the function can produce it without you. Documented procedure, trained people, a deputy who has actually run a cycle, and a review discipline in which someone other than the author checks the number. The measure is the report that goes out while you are on leave.

That the people in it get better. Every cycle is a training opportunity that is usually wasted. The mechanism is giving people numbers to own, early, with a review — and then defending their number in the room rather than replacing it, which is how ownership becomes real.

— 3. Setting a controls strategy

A controls strategy is not a statement of intent. It is a set of decisions that, once made, determine what the function can and cannot tell anyone. The instrument is a controls execution plan — [TPL-01](#) provides the template and [BPG-01 – Building a project controls function from zero](#) covers standing one up — and these are the decisions inside it that a leader personally owns.

The data model. The work breakdown structure, the cost breakdown structure and the code of accounts, and the mapping between them, the contract's payment structure and the finance system. Get this wrong and every reconciliation for the life of the project is manual.

Level of detail. Set by what must be separately measured and controlled. Too coarse and variance cannot be attributed; too fine and the cycle cannot be completed in time to matter.

Progress rules. Which rules of credit apply to which types of work, agreed before anyone claims anything. Retrofitting rules of credit to work already claimed is an argument nobody wins.

The calendar and the cut-off. Data date, cut-off time, who owes what by when, when the report publishes and into which decision. Published in advance and enforced.

Change and trend thresholds. What value triggers a trend, what triggers a change order, who approves at each level, and what may never be absorbed silently.

Contingency governance. Who holds it, who may release it, on what evidence, and how the drawdown is recorded.

Reporting hierarchy. What the project director sees weekly, what the board sees monthly, what the client sees contractually — and the rule that these are views of one position, never three positions.

The assurance regime. What is checked, by whom, how often, and what happens when a check fails.

Two of these are frequently deferred and should never be: the data model and the progress rules. Both become effectively unchangeable once work is under way.

— 4. Running a function rather than performing one

Capacity against cycle demand. A controls function has a sharply peaked workload. Plan the peak, not the average, and know which activities can be moved out of the peak — commitment reconciliation and trend review can; accrual cannot.

Deputising properly. A deputy who has never run the cycle is not a deputy. Someone else runs a full cycle, with you available and not intervening, before you need them to.

The review discipline. Someone other than the author checks every published number. This is not distrust; it is the same principle as any control environment. In practice it catches mapping errors, data-date mismatches and stale accruals — the errors that are invisible to the person who made them.

Hiring for the gap in the map. [CAR-01](#) §2 sets out the six disciplines. Hire against the discipline your function is thin in, and against the entry route ([CAR-02](#)) whose strengths you lack — not against the title of the person who left.

Developing by handing over exposure. The transition described in [CAR-03](#) §6 and [CAR-04](#) §6 is something you can grant. Give a cost engineer the forecast, or a planning engineer the driving-path narrative, before they are obviously ready, and review it rather than rewriting it.

— 5. The relationship with the project director

This relationship is constructed, not discovered, and the construction happens before the first difficult number, not during it.

Agree the escalation contract in the first weeks. What you will bring immediately, what waits for the report, and what you will never sit on. A workable default: any movement above an agreed threshold, any event that changes the completion date, and any number that has become uncertain enough that you would not sign it — all reported the day you know, not at month-end.

Never surprise them in public. A director who hears a bad number first in front of their own leadership will remember it far longer than the number. The corollary is the rule that no new figure appears in a meeting for the first time: if it is material, it was pre-briefed.

Bring the number with the decisions attached. A forecast movement presented alone invites the question "what are you doing about it", which is not your decision to make alone. A movement presented with two or three options, their cost, and the date by which each stops being available, is a management input.

Separate the number from the recommendation, explicitly. "The forecast is X" and "I recommend Y" are different statements with different authority. Conflating them lets a disagreement about the recommendation contaminate the number, which is the beginning of the pressure described in [ETH-03 – Reporting numbers under pressure](#).

Know where the line is. Being asked to present a number differently, to defer publication by a week, or to show a sensitivity is ordinary management. Being asked to state a position you believe to be untrue is not, and it is a conduct matter with a defined route. A controls leader who has not thought about that line in advance will meet it unprepared.

— 6. Being believed: the movement bridge and the habits around it

Credibility in this function is built from a small number of unglamorous behaviours.

Reconcile to one source. Cost, commercial, schedule and risk report from the same data at the same data date. Where they differ, the difference is explained in the report, not resolved privately.

Never move a number silently. Every movement is bridged. The bridge — worked through in §8 — decomposes the change between last period's position and this one into named causes, and separates fact from judgement. Its effect on a meeting is out of proportion to the effort: it converts

"why has your number gone up again" into "do we accept this one assumption", which is a discussion you can have.

Pre-brief the people who will be asked. Anyone who will be questioned about the number in a forum you are not in should have heard it from you first, with the same explanation.

Be first to report your own error. Nothing purchases credibility as cheaply, and nothing destroys it as thoroughly as an error found by someone else that you already knew about. The correct form is the error, its cause, its effect on the reported position, and the control that will stop it recurring.

Say the same thing to everyone. Different audiences get different levels of detail, never different positions. The moment two versions exist, the function's independence is gone and cannot be rebuilt on that project.

When you are overruled, record it and move on. Note the position you gave, the decision taken and the date, in the ordinary record rather than in a private file. Do not re-litigate it in every subsequent meeting, and do not leak it. If the decision requires you to publish something untrue, that is the different matter described in §5.

— 7. How this goes wrong

Remaining the best analyst in the room. The most common failure. The function's output ceiling becomes your personal throughput, the team never develops, and the position collapses the moment you are unavailable.

Building a report pack nobody reads. Volume is mistaken for rigour. [BPG-14 – Monthly reporting that gets read](#) owns the remedy; the leadership point is that a report is an instrument of decision, and if no decision has ever changed because of it, its length is not the problem.

Reorganising before diagnosing. New controls leaders frequently restructure the team in the first cycle. Almost always the problem is the data model, the cut-off or the rules of credit, and a reorganisation moves the same broken process between different people.

Confusing independence with distance. A controls function that is never on site, never in the procurement meeting and never in the subcontract negotiation is not independent; it is uninformed, and its numbers arrive too late to alter anything.

Managing the message instead of the position. Softening a number to preserve a relationship works exactly once. The second time, the audience discounts everything the function says, including the numbers that were never softened.

Never developing a successor. A leader who cannot be promoted because nobody can replace them has optimised for indispensability, which is a ceiling disguised as security.

Assuming the credential does the persuading. The Institute certifies knowledge against a published standard; PCI is developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles and is not accredited. Credibility in a project meeting is built from bridged numbers and kept promises, and nothing else substitutes.

— 8. Worked example — the movement bridge

Illustrative figures. Currency-neutral units, one project, month-on-month, rounded to the nearest thousand. Assumptions: same data date convention both periods; no change to the contract price;

the risk provision and the forecast are maintained separately so that a released risk reduces the forecast rather than the budget.

Last period's forecast final cost: 24,600,000. This period's: 25,380,000. Movement: +780,000.

Presented like that, the meeting is about 780,000 and about you. Bridged, it is about one number.

Line	Cause	Movement	Fact or judgement
1	Variations approved in the period, priced and instructed	+310,000	Fact
2	Scope identified as omitted from the estimate at handover, now quantified	+120,000	Fact
3	Productivity deterioration on two control accounts, forecast at the achieved rate	+295,000	Judgement
4	Risk retired without occurring; provision released from the forecast	−90,000	Fact
5	Subcontract re-let above the estimate carried in the forecast, award executed	+145,000	Fact
Total movement		+780,000	

Check the bridge ties. $310,000 + 120,000 = 430,000$; $430,000 + 295,000 = 725,000$; $725,000 - 90,000 = 635,000$; $635,000 + 145,000 = 780,000$. And $24,600,000 + 780,000 = 25,380,000$, which is the reported position. A bridge that does not tie exactly to the reported movement is worse than no bridge.

What the bridge does to the conversation. Four of the five lines are facts — instructions issued, scope quantified, a risk that did not occur, a subcontract awarded at a known value. They are not arguable, only regrettable. One line is a forecasting judgement: $295,000 \div 780,000 = 37.8\%$ of the movement. The other 62.2 % is arithmetic on things that have already happened.

So the meeting should be about 295,000, and specifically about one question: is the productivity shortfall structural or recoverable? That question has an owner, an evidence base and a test date, and it can be answered. "Why has your number gone up by 780,000" cannot be answered at all, which is why the unbridged version of this conversation is where credibility is lost.

The second-order use. Keep the bridges. Twelve of them are a record of how your forecast behaved across a project: which lines recurred, which judgements were vindicated, how much of the total movement was ever within the function's control. That record is a leadership evidence set in the sense of [CAR-07](#), and there are very few better answers to "how do you know your forecasting is any good".

— 9. Checklist — before you take the role, and in the first cycle after

- Read the contract yourself, including the payment mechanism, change mechanism and notice provisions. Do not accept a summary.
- Establish the escalation contract with the project director in writing, however informally, in the first weeks.

- Confirm the data model and the progress rules. If either is wrong, that is the first thing you change and the only thing worth restructuring for.
- Publish the reporting calendar backwards from the decisions it must serve, and enforce the cut-off once.
- Name your deputy and schedule the cycle they will run without you.
- Institute the review rule: no published number unchecked by someone other than its author.
- Start the movement bridge in your first reporting cycle, even if the movement is small. It is far harder to introduce during a difficult month.
- Identify the one control that would have caught the last unpleasant surprise on this project, and install it.
- Decide, before you are tested, what you will do if you are asked to publish a position you believe to be untrue.

A controls leader is ultimately judged on a single counterfactual: did the organisation make a different and better decision because the function existed? Accuracy is how you earn the right to be asked. Being believed is how the answer becomes yes.

— Related

- [CAR-03 – Cost engineer to cost manager](#) — the cost ladder that leads here
- [CAR-04 – Planner to planning manager](#) — the planning ladder that leads here
- [CAR-07 – Building a portfolio of evidence](#) — how to evidence leadership work, including the bridges
- [CAR-08 – The first ninety days in a controls role](#) — the entry plan, which applies with more force at this level
- [BPG-01 – Building a project controls function from zero](#) — the standing-up problem in full
- [BPG-14 – Monthly reporting that gets read](#) — the reporting craft assumed in §7
- [TPL-01 – Project controls execution plan](#) — the instrument that records the decisions in §3

— Sources and standards

Drawn from the PCI Body of Knowledge, principally Domain 4 (performance management, variance analysis and management reporting), Domain 8 (project management lifecycle) and Domain 12 (risk management for project controls); and from the PCL-AI competency set, in particular project controls governance, performance measurement and human validation. The Institute's accreditation status is stated as published: developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles, not accredited. No pay, market or demand data has been used; see [SAL-01](#) and [SAL-06](#).

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